



18Dragon

RAILWAYS IN A FANTASY LAND

Rulebook · E. Halsey Miles

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The Year 1822 P.V.

The Empire ended in an afternoon. A Varstovan clerk still dates her contracts by it and never thinks about the number she is writing — 1822 P.V., Post Verantum.

Before that day the Empire was the world. Verantum's roads ran from the northern harbors down to the southern sand, and any governor who wanted a decision wrote to Verantia and waited. Then the island cracked and Verantia burned. What did it, the histories still argue. Fire out of a clear sky, say the Caelish annals. A working of the imperial magi that got away from them, say the magi, who would know. In Gördum they say something old woke up under the sea and the Empire had only itself to blame for the noise it had been making. Scholars set that year at zero and named the age after the wound.

The provinces buried what they could and became kingdoms. Caelimor took the northwest, a wet green country of harbors and moor, ruled out of Draeven. Gördum shut its mountain gates and kept its forges lit, dwarven and unbothered, under Brekheim. Varstova made a nation out of ledgers and toll roads in the eastern hills, and Varstgrad counted the take. Muravel inherited the southern plains and the caravan roads that cross them, which is how Kalavar got rich. Verantum itself is an island of empty cities. Verantia is a field of broken marble; Corvium, Ostia, and Litoria stand behind their walls with nothing inside them, and every generation produces men who swear they can be filled again.

For eighteen centuries nothing moved faster than a horse. Then the dwarves of Gördum went back through the mounds, the old spoil hills above the deep workings, and found seams of phlogiston in them. It is a heavy red earth that takes fire the way stone takes heat and gives it back for days. Gördum sold it abroad as a curiosity, mostly to alchemists, and thought no more about it.

The College of Magi at Draeven thought a great deal about it. In 1799 P.V. they published the phlogiston engine, a device that would turn a wheel as long as you fed it. They were applauded. Then they discovered that nothing in Draeven particularly needed a wheel turned, and the paper sat in the College library for five years.

Dwarves read papers.

In 1804 P.V., in a shed behind the Brekheim forgeworks, dwarven craftsmen bolted a Draeven engine to an iron frame, packed the box with Gördum phlogiston, and ran the thing four miles up a mine track and four back with eleven tons of ore behind it. Within ten years there was rail under every deep hall in the kingdom, and every court above ground had an opinion about it.

This spring, Brekheim Forgeworks Rail announced service open to anyone who pays: Brekheim out to the mountain gates, published schedule, published fare. In Draeven the magi are still arguing over the patent, which they will lose. In Kalavar the caravan masters have seen the fare table and understood it. And in Varstgrad, where nobody has laid a foot of track, the houses did the thing Varstova does best. They worked out what a railway costs.

More than any one man has. That is the whole of it: no one can pay for a railway alone, so a company is chartered — its shares cut into tenths — and strangers put up the money for a piece of what the trains bring back. A small line has one owner and keeps every coin it earns. A great company has a president who paid for the chair and holds the largest block of its stock — a fifth at the least, and usually a good deal more — the rest scattered among other investors, and a board that will unseat them if the dividends disappoint. And a share is not worth what it cost. It is worth what the Varstgrad floor says this afternoon.

The floor opened to railway paper before the thaw and has not been quiet since. It says a new number every time a company pays out, issues more paper, or fails to reach a town it promised. Half the men shouting on it will never see a locomotive.

So: the charters are being drawn up, the exchange is open, and nothing out there is built yet. Bring your money.

How to Read This Book

18Dragon is a **variant of 1822**. This book is complete — you need no other rulebook to play — but a reader who already knows 1822 can move quickly. Every rule that differs from base 1822 is printed in **blue**; rules printed in black are 1822's, unchanged. The **Differences from 1822** appendix at the back gathers every change in one place.

Money is measured in **ducats**, shown throughout with a gold coin beside the amount, as on the game's components — so 150 is 150 ducats. Throughout, a minor company is written **M_x** and a private company **P_x**, where x is its number (for example M7, P28).

Components

- The **map board** — the five regions (Caelimor, Gördum, Varstova, Muravel, and the Verantum island) with the round/phase track.
- The **board mat** — the stock market and the bidding boxes (4 minor + 3 private).
- **10 major company charters** and **30 minor company charters**.
- **Certificates:** for each major, one President's certificate (20%) and eight shares (10% each); one 50% director's certificate for each of the **30 minors**.
- **30 private company cards** — some carry a special train (2P, LP, 5P, P+) on the back.
- **63 train cards** — L/2 (22, double-sided), 3 (9), 4 (6), 5 (3), 6 (3), and 7/E (20, double-sided).
- **Track tiles** — yellow, green, brown, and grey, including the labelled-city tiles and the Verantum ruins tiles.
- **Tokens** — station tokens, share-price and round markers, and four bid cubes per player, with their sticker sheets.
- **Player-order cards** (1–6) and a bank of money in **ducats**.

1. Overview

Sequence of Play

The game is an alternating series of **stock rounds** and **operating rounds**. In a stock round, players act as investors: bidding for minor and private companies and buying and selling shares in the major companies. The player holding the most shares in a company is its **director**.

In an operating round, players act as directors, running the companies they control — laying track, placing station tokens, running trains, paying or withholding dividends, and buying trains.

Initially one operating round follows each stock round. Once the first 2-train is bought, two operating rounds follow each stock round.

From Phase 2 onward, a **merger round** follows every operating round. In it, a player who is the **director** of two connected minor companies in different regions may merge them into a major company (see §6). Merging is one of the two ways a major forms — the other is **converting** a single minor into a major, a stock-round action from Phase 5 (§4).

The abilities of private companies often override the normal rules; where a private's ability contradicts a rule, the private's ability wins.

The Map

The map is a hex grid on which track tiles are laid. Every hex belongs to one of five regions — Caelimor (N), Gördum (G), Varstova (V), Muravel (M), or the Verantum island (A) — shown by a coloured region letter that stays visible even under a placed tile.

Cities are drawn as large open circles; each circle is a **station**. A station bearing a company's logo is that company's **home station**; a station bearing a number is the home of the correspondingly-numbered minor. A station holding a token is *occupied*, otherwise *unoccupied*. A company logo printed in a hex with a black banner, but not in a station, marks that company's **destination** city. Small circles and bars are towns and villages (*dits*): a route may run through them but cannot place a token there. Some hexes begin with pre-printed track or fixed grey terrain, and off-board areas around the edges serve as destinations or company homes.

Building is permit-gated. Laying a *new* yellow tile in a region requires the operating company to hold that region's **permit**; upgrading an existing tile does not (see §5).

The Verantum island (A) is reached only across the map's bridge hexes. Its ruined cities begin nearly worthless but can grow into the richest destinations on the board. At its heart is **Verantia**, a fixed grey **ruins city** with four station slots and a base value of 10; it grows only as the ruins hexes around it are developed into **metros**, up to a cap of 100 (see §5).

The Bank

The bank holds 12,000, including the players' starting money. The **bank pool** holds shares sold back to the bank and trains discarded to it; players and companies may buy pool items under the normal rules.

The Stock Market

The *stock market* is a single linear track. A company's **share price** is the position of its stock-market token along it. In *descending share-price order*, the company furthest along the track acts first; if tokens share a space, the topmost acts first.

Companies start (par) at one of nine prices: 50, open to minor companies only, or 55, 60, 65, 70, 75, 80, 90, or 100, open to majors and minors alike.

Setting Up the Game

18Dragon plays with 3 to 6 players.

Lay out the board and the board mat (the stock market and the bidding boxes), and place the major certificates, charters, and station tokens nearby. Sort the track tiles by colour and set them beside the board.

Give each player their starting money and **four bid cubes**. The certificate limit and starting cash depend on the number of players:

Players	3	4	5	6
Certificate limit	16	16	16	13
Starting cash	375	375	375	300

The board scales with the player count. Only some regions are in play: at 3 players, Verantum (A), Caelimor (N), and Gördum (G); at 4 players, add Varstova (V); at 5 or 6 players, add Muravel (M) as well. A region that is not in play removes its six minors, its two majors, and its permit private from the game, and its hexes cannot be built — no company can hold that region's permit.

Seed the bidding boxes (four minor boxes and three private boxes): the **opener minor**, **M16**, starts in minor bidding box 1, and the **opener private**, **P1**, in private bidding box 1 (**P1** carries the permanent 5-train, §2). Shuffle the remaining minor and private certificates into face-up stacks and fill the other boxes from them, lowest-numbered first.

Place the round marker on **SR**, deal the player-order cards (1–6) to set the seating order, and begin play with a stock round.

2. Game Phases

Play advances through seven **phases**. Each phase begins the moment the first train of a new type is bought or **exported** (removed from the bank without a sale — see §4). A phase change takes effect immediately — except that the increase to two operating rounds per stock

round waits until the following stock round. When a phase change causes a train type to rust, those trains are removed from the game at once, without compensation; a company then holding more trains than the new limit

allows discards the excess (deciding in descending share-price order if several must).

Phase	Starts when	Train limit (minor / major)	Highest tile	ORs per SR
1	game start	2 / 4	yellow	1
2	first 2- or 3-train bought	2 / 4	yellow	2
3	first 3-train bought	2 / 4	green	2
4	first 4-train bought	1 / 3	green	2
5	first 5-train bought	1 / 2	brown	2
6	first 6-train bought	1 / 2	brown	2
7	first 7- or E-train bought	1 / 2	grey	2

From Phase 2 onward, a **merger round** follows every **operating round** (§6). From Phase 5, a major company may acquire an unstarted minor from the bidding boxes for 🟡200 (§5).

Trains are bought from the bank. The **L** and **2** share one double-sided card — an **L** upgrades to a **2** for 🟡80 — as do the **7** and **E**. The **5**, **6**, **7**, and **E** are permanent and never rust; an **E** run to a company's destination doubles that city's value (§5).

Trains

Train	Cost	In the game	Rusts when
L	🟡60	22 (L/2 cards)	first 3-train
2	🟡120	—	first 4-train
3	🟡200	9	first 6-train
4	🟡300	6	first 7/E-train
5	🟡500	3	permanent
6	🟡600	3	permanent
7	🟡750	20 (7/E cards)	permanent
E	🟡1,000	—	permanent

The **special trains** — 2P, LP, 5P, and P+ — are not bought from the bank; each comes from a private company, printed on the back of its card (§3). The **opener private** carries the permanent 5-train (5P), which may not be bought into a company until Phase 5.

At 3 or 4 players, some 3- and 4-trains may be removed during setup — fewer companies need fewer trains. This is a provisional adjustment, to be confirmed in playtest.

3. Corporate Entities

18Dragon has three kinds of company — private companies, minor companies, and major companies. It has none of 1822's concessions: the concession certificates that 1822 uses to start major companies do not exist in 18Dragon.

Private Companies

There are **30 private companies**. A private is bought only through the bidding mechanism of a stock round. While a player owns it, it pays a fixed revenue at the start

of each operating round (for some, this is 🟡0) and counts against that player's certificate limit. A private has no share value; it cannot be sold to the bank or traded between players. A minor or major company may acquire a private only from the **player** who owns it — never from another company — at the start of its operating turn, and a private's special power is used only by its owning company, on that company's turn. A minor may take on only those privates open to minors.

Two kinds of private are worth singling out:

- **The five permit privates** — one for each region. While a player owns it, it pays 🟡10 each operating round; when it is bought into a company it closes at once and becomes a **permanent permit** for its region in that company (§5).
- **Player-count privates** — some privates come into play only at higher player counts; a private marked 4+ or 5+ is left out when that many players are not present (§1).

Minor Companies

There are **30 minor companies, six in each region**.

A minor has a single director's certificate worth 50% (two shares); there are no other shares to buy, and its director is simply its owner. A minor is bought only through the bidding mechanism of a stock round and, once bought, is never sold — though a major company may **acquire** it (§5) or **merge** it into a new major (§6). A minor lays one yellow tile, or upgrades one tile to green, per operating round, and may never build past green. Its earnings are always split — half to its treasury, half to its owner. A minor must own a train at the end of its operating turn.

Every minor automatically holds a **permit** for its home region. Minors are also the raw material of major companies: during a merger round, two connected minors in different regions **may** be merged to form a major company (§6), and from Phase 5 a single minor may be **converted** into a major in a stock round (§4). Every major descends from at least one minor — which is how a major comes by its first permit.

Major Companies

There are **ten major companies, two associated with each region**. A major's stock is nine certificates — a President's certificate worth 20% (two shares) and eight further 10% shares. The President's certificate is always held by the largest shareholder, who directs the company; should another player come to hold more, the presidency passes to them. No player may buy past 60% of a major, though a player may reach 100% through the shares received when the company acquires minors (§5). Each major has a destination city, printed on the board and on its charter (running home-to-destination doubles its value, §5). A major lays one yellow tile per operating round in Phase 2, and from Phase 3 on either lays up to two yellow tiles or upgrades one. Its earnings may be paid out, withheld, or split half and half. A major must own a train at the end of its operating turn.

A major is never set up at the start of the game. It comes into being either by **merging two minors in a merger round** (§6), or — from **Phase 5** — by **converting a single minor in a stock round** (§4). A major is never parred directly; it always grows out of a minor. A formed major starts with six tokens: its placed **home token**, a **destination token**, one **available token**, and **three exchange tokens** held in reserve, which become placeable as it later acquires minors (§5, §6).

4. Stock Rounds

A stock round is played in turns, beginning with the holder of the **Player 1** card and proceeding in player order until every player passes in succession. All certificate transfers are between a player and the bank or a company; players never buy or sell shares directly to one another.

A Turn

On your turn you may do the following, in order (or pass and do nothing):

1. **Sell** any number of certificates.
2. **Repay** any player loans.
3. Do **one** of: buy a single share, or place or raise up to three bids in the bidding boxes.

You may not buy a share or place a bid while you hold a player loan.

Certificate Limit

Every certificate you hold — company shares and privates alike — counts toward the certificate limit for the player count (§1). A player at the limit may take no action that would exceed it, and a player found over the limit must sell down to it at the first opportunity.

Selling Shares

You may sell any number of ordinary shares into the bank pool, receiving the current share price for each. Private and minor companies are never sold. You may not sell shares in a company that has not yet operated, no more than 50% of a company may sit in the pool, and a major's **President's certificate** is never sold into the pool. If a sale drops your holding below another player's, the presidency passes to that player (exchanging the President's certificate for two ordinary shares). *Each share sold moves the company's token one step lower along the market track.*

Buying Shares

You may buy **one** certificate per turn, from the bank pool or a company's treasury, at its share price. You may not buy shares in a company you sold this round, nor buy past 60% of a company (though acquiring minors can carry a holding to 100%, §5). Buying does not move the share price.

Player Loans

A player forced to fund a train purchase may have to take a **loan** (§5): you receive the cash you need and immediately owe **150%** of it (borrow 🟡100, owe 🟡150). While you hold a loan you may not buy shares or place bids; you may repay it (in full or part) in your repay step. Any balance still unpaid at the end of the next stock round accrues a **further 50%** on the amount remaining — and again each stock round it goes unpaid — and any debt still held at game end is subtracted from your wealth.

Bidding

Companies are auctioned through the **bidding boxes** — *four boxes for minor companies and three for private companies.* Each player has *four bid cubes*. On your bid

action you may **place and/or raise up to three bids** in the boxes this turn — placing a cube on an empty space of a box, or raising one of your bids by moving its cube to a higher space on the same item (you may raise your own bid only after another player has outbid you on it). A bid, once placed, cannot be withdrawn; each cube in play counts against your certificate limit as though it were the item.

Forming a Major Company

A major company forms in one of two ways: by **merger of two minors**, at any time from Phase 2 (§6), or from **Phase 5 by converting** a single minor in a stock round. *A major is never parred directly — every major grows out of a minor, and so is born holding at least one region permit (§5).*

Converting a Minor to a Major

From **Phase 5**, in place of buying a share, you may convert a minor company you direct into a major company. Choose an **available major associated with that minor's region** (each region has two, §3); if neither is available, that minor cannot be converted. Then:

1. **Value.** Double the minor's current share price. This is the amount the new major must pay you.
2. **Par.** Choose the major's par price from 🟡55 to 🟡100. It must be at least the value ÷ 6.
3. **Shares.** Divide the value by the par and round to a whole number of shares — you receive that many shares of the new major, including its **President's certificate**. You must receive at least **two** shares, since the President's certificate is worth two; if the chosen par would give fewer, choose a lower par. If the number was rounded **up**, you pay the company the difference; if rounded **down**, the company pays you.
4. **Assets.** Move the minor's cash, trains, and privates onto the major's charter, and remove the minor from play. The minor's certificate becomes a **permit** for its region inside the major (§5).
5. **Home token.** The minor's board token becomes the major's home station.
6. **Tokens.** The major takes its tokens onto its charter: its **home token** (placed at the minor's location), a **destination token**, **one available token**, and **three exchange tokens** held in reserve (§6).

7. Capitalisation. A converted major, like a merged one, is always funded **incrementally** — its treasury grows as players buy its shares.

The major does not operate until it **floats** — when 50% of its shares have been sold — and then operates from the next operating round.

Ending the Stock Round

When all players pass in succession the round ends. Resolve the bids: in turn, each high bidder pays for and takes their item. Minor companies won from the boxes then float: the buyer pays the bid, the minor's **starting share price** is the winning bid halved and rounded down to the nearest par value (🟡50 in the first stock round), and its **treasury** is set from the bid — twice the starting price through Phase 2, and the full bid from Phase 3 on. Each minor that received **no bid exports an L-train** — one L is removed from the bank without payment (if no L remains, nothing is exported). Then, if a minor is still sitting in **bidding box 1** unsold, it is re-

moved from play and exports the **next available train** as well. Because a box-1 minor is itself unbid, while L-trains remain it triggers **both** — an L, then the next train — so a single minor can export two trains. An exported train advances the phase exactly as a purchase would (§2). Unsold **privates** neither export nor leave — they simply remain in their bidding boxes, available in later rounds until bought. Any **player loan** still unpaid now accrues a **further 50%** on the balance remaining (§4 *Player Loans*). Finally, the player-order cards for the next round are dealt by **cash on hand** — the **Player 1** card to the player with the most cash, and so on. Players tied on cash keep their **current relative order**.

Share Price Movement

At the end of the stock round, each company that is **sold out** — with none of its shares remaining in its own treasury or in the bank pool — moves one space higher on the market track. (A minor company is never fully sold, since only its 50% director's certificate exists.)

5. Operating Rounds

First, every open private company pays its revenue to its owner. Then the companies operate one at a time — **minor companies first**, in descending share-price order, then **major companies**, in descending share-price order. When companies share a market space the one on top runs first; otherwise the one further along the track runs first.

A Company's Turn

When a company operates, its director may take the following actions, in this order. Most are optional; those marked are compulsory.

1. First-turn housekeeping (first turn only).
2. Acquire private companies from willing players.
3. Lay or upgrade track.
4. (*Majors*) Check for a connection to the destination, and place the destination token.
5. (*Majors*) Place one station token.
6. Run trains to establish earnings — **compulsory**.
7. Pay, split, or withhold dividends.
8. Buy trains.

9. (*Majors*) Acquire a minor company.

10. (*Majors*) Issue or redeem stock.

First-Turn Housekeeping

On a company's **first** operating turn, its director places the company's free **home token** on its home city, if it is not already on the board. A major company's home token is placed when the company forms — at the location of the merged or converted minor that provided its home (§4, §6) — so only a **minor** places its home token here. A minor company may also, on this first turn only, buy one **L-train** from the bank or bank pool if any remain.

Acquiring Private Companies

In this step a company (major or minor) may acquire private companies from **consenting players**, provided the private's phase requirement — printed on its card — has been met; privates may be acquired only in this step, and no compensation is paid to the seller. An acquired private is flipped onto the company's charter and continues to pay its revenue to the owning company until it is closed by using its power (some close at once, handing over a power, token, or tile). Each private's card shows

which companies may take it in — some are open to majors only, others to majors or minors — and there is no limit on the number a company may acquire in a turn. Taking in one of the **region permit privates** closes it and grants its region's permit (§5); taking in the opener private grants its permanent 5-train — a company may take it even at the train limit, then discard down.

Laying and Upgrading Track

Laying track is optional. A company may lay and upgrade up to its per-turn tile allowance (§3), or lay fewer tiles, or none. Yellow tiles are placed on the map's buildable hexes and later **upgraded in order** — yellow to green (from Phase 3), green to brown (Phase 5), brown to grey (Phase 7) — never skipping a colour; the replaced tile returns to the bank for reuse elsewhere. Each tile must obey the following:

- The company must be able to trace a **route across the new track** once it is placed — a lay must connect to the company's own network. If it lays two tiles, they need not connect to each other. *(On a company's home hex, if no track is there yet, it may lay a suitable yellow city tile even without a connection.)*
- The tile must **match the hex**: plain, town, double-town, or city (a labelled city takes only its matching tiles).
- Track may not run **off the grid**, into a blank hex edge, or to a red-bordered edge.
- An upgrade must **preserve all existing track** — every route that existed before the upgrade must still exist after it. Track is never removed once laid.
- Building through **difficult terrain** (rivers, hills, mountains) costs the fee printed on the hex; a company that cannot pay the fee cannot build there.
- Tiles other than plain track are limited in supply; if every copy of a needed tile is already in play, one must first be freed by upgrading a hex that holds it.

Building is permit-gated. Laying a new yellow tile in a region requires the operating company to hold that region's permit. Upgrading a tile requires no permit, and once a hex has been opened with yellow, any company may upgrade it. A permit is held **permanently** — never used up or lost — and a company may hold permits for several regions at once.

A company comes to hold a region's permit in one of three ways: every **minor** automatically holds the permit for its **home region** (§3); a **region permit private** becomes a permanent permit for its region when it is bought into a company (see Acquiring Private Companies, above); and when a minor is **merged into** or **acquired by** a major, that minor's certificate carries its region's permit into the major (see Acquiring a Minor below, and §6).

Verantum ruins hexes develop in their own way. A ruins hex may be built into plain track, a dit, a **city** (a yellow city tile, ●20 — this is how a second island city is founded), or a **metro** (the dead-end stub tile **Xo1**, laid in yellow for ●10 and upgraded to the green **Xo2** or **Xo3**, then the brown **Xo4**; see Running Trains). New yellow on the island needs the region A permit like anywhere else; once a yellow tile is laid, the hex is committed to its type and only upgrades along the normal paths (a dit never becomes a city — except by private P21). Apart from the metro rules above, plain track, dits, and city tiles behave as they do anywhere else on the map.

The Destination Token

After its track-laying step, a major company checks whether it can trace a route of any length from its **home city** to its **destination city**. The first time it can, it must at once place its free **destination token** (marked with a black banner) in the destination city; this cannot be deferred. Running a train from home to the destination thereafter doubles the destination's value (see Running Trains).

Station Tokens

A major company may place one station token per turn in a city it can reach along a route and that has an open slot, paying the token's cost printed on its charter. The token comes from the major's **available** tokens — the box on its charter separate from its reserve **exchange** tokens (see Acquiring a Minor). A minor company has only its single home token.

Running Trains

If a company owns trains, it runs them to establish its earnings. Each train runs a **route**: a continuous, unbranched length of track that includes at least one of the company's **station tokens** and connects **revenue loc-**

ations — cities, towns, and off-board areas. A route earns the sum of the values of the locations it reaches.

- A train's **number is the most revenue locations it may reach**, and it must reach at least two; it may not skip an intermediate location on its route. The **L-train** is the exception: it runs one city holding the company's token plus, optionally, one adjacent town (a "1+1").
- A route may not use any track segment twice, nor reach the same city or town twice. When a company runs several trains, their routes may **share revenue locations but not track segments**.
- A route is **blocked** by a city or off-board area whose slots are entirely filled by other companies' tokens: a train may start or end there, but not pass through it.
- Off-board areas pay a value that rises with the phase (yellow → green → brown → grey).
- The **E-train** stops only at cities and off-board areas holding the company's own token, passing everything else without counting it, and **doubles** the value of each stop it counts; it has no reach limit beyond the company's tokens and routes, and never stops at a town.

A company that runs a train from its **home city to its destination city** doubles the destination's value — for one train per turn. An E-train run over that route doubles the already-doubled destination, so it counts four-fold. A company's earnings are the sum of all its routes' values; the director declares them, and the highest legal total any player identifies must be used.

On Verantum, each metro built adjacent to a ruins city adds its value to that city: the yellow metro **Xo1** adds 10; upgraded to green, the **Xo2** adds 20, or the branch **Xo3** adds 10 to each of two adjacent cities; upgraded again to brown, the **Xo4** adds 30. A ruins city's value is **capped at 100** (base plus metros). Because metros are dead ends, a train can reach a ruins city only by a non-metro approach — ring a city entirely in metros and no train can run to it.

Dividends

After running, a company distributes its earnings. A **minor company always splits** them — half to its treasury, half to its owner. A **major company** may keep all its earnings in the treasury, pay them all out as a divi-

dend, or pay **half** (rounded up to the next 10) and keep the rest.

When a dividend is paid, each 10% share earns a tenth of it: a shareholder is paid for the shares they hold, the company is paid for shares in its own treasury, and the bank keeps the share of any in the pool.

The dividend then moves the company's price along the market track:

- **Minor:** any non-zero dividend moves the price one space higher; paying nothing moves it one space lower.
- **Major:** withholding (or a dividend of 0) moves it one space lower; a dividend at least equal to the share price moves it one space higher; a dividend at least **twice** the share price moves it two; and a dividend at **least three times the share price, when the price is 150 or less, moves it three** (a "triple jump").

Buying Trains

A company below the train limit may buy trains. From the **bank**, trains are bought at face value and **in order** — no train of a new type may be bought until the previous type is sold out or exported (each such first purchase advances the phase, §2). From **Phase 3** a company may also buy a train from **another company**, with that company's consent, for any price from 1 up to the buyer's treasury.

A company may buy **several trains** in one turn, one after another (each purchase's effects, including any phase change and rusting, apply before the next). A company **at** the train limit may not buy; a company **below** it may buy even if the purchase triggers a phase change that then puts it over the limit — it discards the excess afterward (§2).

A company that ran and owns **no train** must buy one (a 2P, LP, or Pullman does not satisfy this requirement; the 5P, a true 5-train, does). If it cannot afford one, a **forced purchase** occurs: it must buy the cheapest available train, its director making up any shortfall from their own cash. If the director still cannot pay, they raise the money in an emergency — **selling shares** (while keeping their company's director's certificate) and, as a last resort, taking a **player loan** for the remainder at 150% (§4).

The special trains and the Pullman come only from private companies (§3), and all are permanent and never rust. **2P, LP, and the Pullman (P+)** do not count against the train limit and do not satisfy the requirement to own a train; a Pullman simply adds towns to one of the company's trains on its run — up to **twice that train's size** in extra towns. The **5P**, however, is a genuine permanent 5-train: it **counts against the train limit** and **satisfies** the requirement to own a train.

Acquiring a Minor Company

From Phase 2, a major company may acquire **one** minor company per turn, provided both directors consent (often the same player), neither company first operated this round, and the major can trace a route to the minor's home city, or already holds a token there. It pays the minor's **value** — twice the minor's share price — for the minor's director's certificate. The major may hand over **zero, one, or two of its own shares**, each counted at the major's share price; if they come to less than the value, the major makes up the rest in **cash**, and if they come to more, the minor's owner pays the difference back into the major's treasury — so the exchange nets exactly the minor's value. The major takes all the minor's assets: its cash, trains, and privates. For the minor's **sta-**

tion token: if the major has an **exchange token** in reserve, it converts one — either replacing the minor's token on the board with a major token, or removing the minor's token and moving an exchange token to its **available** tokens. **If the major has no exchange token left, it still makes the acquisition, but the minor's token is removed and lost** — the major gains no token from it. The major then discards any trains over its limit. From Phase 5, a major may instead acquire an unstarted minor from the bidding boxes for **200**.

Acquiring a minor also makes that minor's certificate a **permit for its region inside the major** (see *Laying and Upgrading Track*, above) — a major grows both its reach and its building rights by taking in minors.

Issuing and Redeeming Stock

A major company may **issue** or **redeem** its own shares — but not both in one turn, and never issue on its first operating turn. **Issuing** moves shares from the company's treasury to the bank pool: the share price steps down once for each 10% issued, and the company receives the new price for each share sold. **Redeeming** buys shares back from the pool into the treasury at the current price, and does not move the price.

6. Merger Round

New to 18Dragon. 1822 has no merger round. Merging is the chief way major companies come into being (the other is conversion of a single minor from Phase 5, §4).

A **merger round** follows every operating round from **Phase 2** onward (Phase 1's single operating round has none). In it, minor companies may be merged into majors. The chance to merge is offered in **descending share-price order** — the highest-valued eligible minor first; a minor that passes may still be merged later, when a lower-valued minor is offered.

Eligibility

Two minor companies may merge only if **all** of the following hold:

- it is **Phase 2 or later**;
- **one player is the director (owner) of both** minors;

- the two minors lie in **different regions**; and
- their tracks are **connected** by a route of any length, not blocked by other companies' tokens.

Forming the Major

The initiating player chooses which minor provides the **home**, and an **available major associated with that minor's region**. (If that region has no available major, the other minor must provide the home; if neither can, the merger cannot be made.) Then:

1. **Value.** Double each minor's current share price and add the two together. This total is the amount the new major must pay the player.
2. **Par.** Choose the major's par price from **55 to 100**. It must be at least the total ÷ 6; if the total is more than **600**, the par **must** be **100**.
3. **Shares.** Divide the total by the par and round to a whole number of shares — the player receives that

many shares of the new major. If the number was rounded **up**, the player pays the company the difference; if rounded **down**, the company pays the player.

4. **Assets.** Move both minors' cash, trains, and privates onto the major's charter, and remove both minors from play.
5. **Home token.** The home minor's board token becomes the major's home station.
6. **Tokens.** The major takes its tokens onto its charter: its **home** token (placed at the home minor's location), a **destination** token, **one available** token ready to place in later turns, and **three exchange** tokens held in reserve. (Each minor the major later acquires converts one exchange token into an available one, §5.)

7. **The other minor's token — the director's choice:** either replace it on the board with one of the major's tokens, or remove it and move an **exchange** token to the major's available tokens.
8. **Capitalisation.** A merged major is always funded **incrementally** (§4).
9. The major is ready to operate in the **next operating round**.

Exchange Tokens

A major keeps **exchange tokens** in reserve on its charter, apart from its available tokens. An exchange token becomes a placeable, available token when the major **acquires a minor** (§5), or through the **Station Token Swap** private (P28).

7. Game End

The game end is triggered by the first of these to occur. Once triggered, the game ends at the stated time, even if another trigger would fire later.

- The **first stock round ends with nothing bought** — the game ends at once.
- A company's token **reaches the game-end space** on the market track — the game ends at the end of the current operating round, or, if the space is reached during a stock round, after the next operating round.

- The **bank runs out of money** — the game ends after the current set of operating rounds is completed. (The bank keeps paying in the meantime; record any shortfall.)

At the end of the game, each player's **wealth** is the value of their shares at current prices, plus their cash on hand, minus any outstanding loans. Private companies and company treasuries count for nothing. The **richest player wins**.

Appendix — Differences from 1822

For a reader who knows 1822, this is every way 18Dragon differs, gathered in one place and keyed to the section that covers it. In the body of the book these same rules are printed in [blue](#).

The headline change

- **No concessions; majors form out of minors.** 1822's concessions are gone. A major company comes into being only by **merging two minors** in a merger round (§6), or by **converting a single minor** in a stock round from Phase 5 (§4). A major is never parred directly, so every major is born holding at least one region permit. Majors are **region-associated** — two per region (§3).

Overview & setup (§1)

- **The map is five fantasy regions** — four across the mainland and the island of Verantum — each hex carrying a coloured region-permit letter (A / N / G / V / M).
- **Building is permit-gated:** laying new yellow in a region needs that region's permit (§5).
- **The board is modular** — regions switch on with player count (A/N/G core; +V at 4; +M at 5–6), and a dropped region's companies, privates, and minors leave with it.

- **The stock market is a single 1D track**, with nine par values (🟡 50 minors-only; 55–🟡 100 majors and minors) and no cert-limit-exempt zone — every certificate counts.
- **Setup:** 3–6 players; certificate limits 16 / 16 / 16 / 13 and starting cash 375 / 375 / 375 / 🟡 300; four bid cubes per player; four minor and three private bidding boxes; the opener minor **M16** and opener private **P1** seed box 1 of each.

Companies (§3)

- **30 private companies** — including five **region-permit privates** (each becomes a permanent regional permit when taken into a company) and privates gated to 4+/5+ players.
- **30 minor companies**, six per region, each automatically holding its **home-region permit**.
- **10 major companies**, two associated with each region.

Rounds & operating (§2, §4, §5)

- **A merger round follows every operating round from Phase 2 (§6).**
- **Major formation is by merger or Phase-5 minor conversion**, never by direct par or concession conversion (§4).
- **Bidding** is over minors and privates only, with four bid cubes each (§4).
- **Track-laying is permit-gated**, and on **Verantum** ruins hexes develop specially — metros (tiles X01/X02/X03/X04) and city tiles — with metros raising an adjacent ruins city's value up to a 🟡 100 cap (§5).
- **Acquiring a minor** also grants its region permit and converts an exchange token (§5).
- **A major's dividend can “triple-jump”** — up three spaces — on a payout of at least three times its share price when its price is 🟡 150 or less (§5).

Trains

- **Base-1822 train roster** (not PNW's); at 3–4 players some 3- and 4-trains may be removed (provisional) (§2).